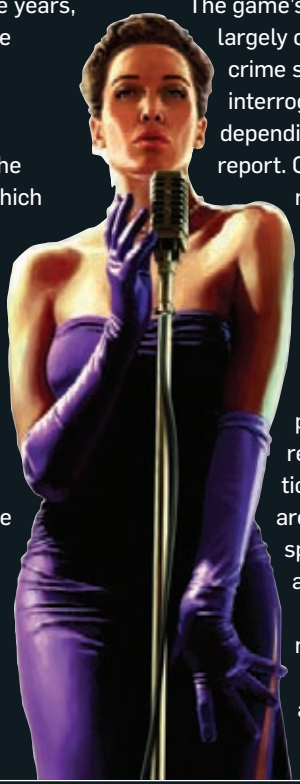
Faiyaz Shaikh
readersletters@thinkdigit.com

L.A. Noire marks the debut of Australia-based Team Bondi studio that was formed in 2003, which seems to indicate that the game has been in development for more than half a decade.

Since the founder of the studio is an ex-Sony employee, the game was originally conceived as a PlayStation 3 exclusive. Over the years, the industry has seen the decline of third-party exclusive games, and L.A. Noire was released on the PS3 and Xbox 360, with PC version to follow. We reviewed the Xbox 360 version of the game which comes on a set of three discs to accommodate Team Bondi's adaptation of mid-1950's Los Angeles and its denizens.

ARMED WITH INTUITION

The game starts right after the end of WWII, with player's taking control of Cole Phelps who is a decorated war hero. The game's main storyline follows the rise and fall of Phelps' career with the Los Angeles police department, and the city's seedy underbelly provides essential fodder for game-play. The game picks up pace once Phelps takes on the mantle of a detective after cracking a case as a patrolman.



The game's investigation system largely comprises of three parts: crime scene investigation, interrogation and sometimes depending on the coroner's report. Central to this mechanism is the interrogation system, while the other two provide ammunition in getting the suspects to spill their guts.

During these interrogations it is up to the player to study suspects' reactions to a question and decide if they are hiding some facts, speaking the truth or are just flat-out lying.

This is the central mechanism of the game which can make or break a case for Phelps.

BREAKTHROUGH TECH

For this the developers have used the impressive 'Depth Analysis' technology which captures the expressions of actors by 32 cameras simultaneously. The game tracks the player's progress as a detective by way of experience points and character level. Each level-up is rewarded with an 'intuition point' which can be used if and when the players find themselves in a tight-spot during an interrogation.

IT'S JUST POLICE WORK

Breaking the drudgery of routine police work are missions (or cases if you will) that involve foot-chases, car chases and all out gun fights. Other than this, there are several side-missions that are more action oriented and can be initiated by responding to a call over the police radio.

These side-missions are also a good source of racking up experience points and subsequently earning intuition points that can be extremely handy in cracking tricky cases in the main storyline.

While L.A. Noire deserves commendation for impressively realizing the game-world and solid facial animation, the game has the potential to drag at times. Ardent fans of old-fashioned adventure or puzzle game may not feel this way, but for me a few of L.A. Noire went a long way.

I found the game enjoyable in smaller doses, with longer sessions starting to feel tedious. While the game has little to no replay value, the game length runs into 20 hours with the main storyline and about equal hours of side-missions.

WHAT WE THINK

Even though the game's cover art and the Rockstar Games label may give that impression, L.A. Noire is nothing like the Mafia series when it comes to game-play. If you love sleuthing around and the idea of putting the rich and the powerful gets you excited, then L.A. Noire should be a pleasant experience.

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